



BSF-QMS-003

Corrective Action and Nonconformity Procedure

Quality Management System | BlueSea Foods

Field	Value	Field	Value
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Purpose

This procedure defines how BlueSea Foods identifies, records, contains, investigates, corrects, verifies, and closes nonconformities and corrective actions affecting product quality, food safety, regulatory compliance, customer requirements, traceability, worker safety, and certification commitments.

1. Scope

This procedure applies to all BlueSea Foods operations, including procurement of seafood raw material, receiving and inspection, cold chain control, processing, storage, dispatch, quality assurance, supplier approval, documentation control, customer complaint handling, internal audits, certification audits, and outsourced activities that may affect product conformity.

It applies to nonconformities detected through routine inspection, process monitoring, temperature deviation, laboratory results, supplier documentation review, customer complaints, internal audits, external audits, regulatory inspections, traceability exercises, workplace safety observations, and management review.

This procedure is mandatory for employees, supervisors, managers, contractors, temporary personnel, and service providers working under BlueSea Foods operational control.

2. Confidentiality

This document is classified as Internal / Controlled. It may contain information about audit findings, suppliers, corrective actions, food safety controls, customer requirements, operational weaknesses, and certification readiness. Distribution is restricted to authorized personnel and external parties approved by Quality Assurance or Senior Management.

Records generated under this procedure must not be shared externally unless required by law, customer contract, certification body request, regulatory authority request, or formal authorization by BlueSea Foods management.

3. Definitions

Term	Definition
Nonconformity	Failure to meet a requirement, specification, procedure, standard, customer requirement, legal requirement, or internal control.
Correction	Immediate action taken to eliminate a detected nonconformity, such as segregation, rework, relabeling, document correction, or product hold.
Corrective Action	Action taken to eliminate the root cause of a nonconformity and prevent recurrence.
Containment	Immediate control to prevent further impact while investigation is ongoing, such as blocking product, stopping shipment, isolating records, or suspending a supplier lot.
Root Cause	The underlying reason that allowed the nonconformity to occur or escape detection.
Effectiveness Verification	Evidence-based confirmation that corrective action has been implemented and has prevented recurrence.
CAPA	Corrective and Preventive Action process used to manage investigation, action plans, verification, and closure.

4. Roles and Responsibilities

Role	Responsibility
Quality Assurance Manager	Owns this procedure, approves major corrective actions, verifies closure for major/critical cases, reports trends to management review, and ensures alignment with certification requirements.
HSE Coordinator	Supports nonconformities related to workplace safety, emergency response, PPE, environmental incidents, chemical handling, and contractor safety.
Operations Manager	Ensures operational containment, allocates resources, approves process changes, and confirms that production teams implement assigned actions.
Receiving Supervisor	Reports receiving nonconformities, places lots on hold when required, secures evidence, and supports supplier-related investigations.
Document Controller	Maintains controlled versions, registers, evidence files, retention rules, and cross-references with the document inventory.
Process Owner	Investigates assigned findings, performs root cause analysis, implements corrective actions, and provides evidence by the due date.
Internal Auditor	Raises audit findings with objective evidence and verifies whether corrective actions address the requirement and root cause.
All Employees	Report deviations, unsafe conditions, quality issues, documentation gaps, and product concerns immediately through the approved reporting channels.

5. Nonconformity Sources

Nonconformities may originate from operational, quality, food safety, compliance, customer, supplier, or worker safety sources. BlueSea Foods treats every credible issue as a controlled record until it is evaluated, dispositioned, and closed.

Source	Typical examples
Receiving and inspection	Temperature above limit, missing vessel authorization, damaged packaging, species mismatch, sensory rejection, incomplete lot documentation.
Cold chain control	Temperature excursion, missing logger data, equipment failure, delayed corrective action, calibration gap.
Processing and storage	Foreign material risk, sanitation failure, label error, allergen control issue, segregation failure, product mix-up.
Supplier or vessel control	Expired authorization, missing catch certificate, high-risk vessel status, inconsistent harvest area, incomplete BASC/MSC evidence.
Audits and inspections	Internal audit finding, certification audit finding, regulatory observation, customer audit request, document gap.
Customer feedback	Complaint, rejection, claim, quality dispute, traceability inquiry, delayed evidence response.
HSE and social compliance	Unsafe act, PPE gap, incident, emergency drill failure, excessive working hours, contractor control gap.

6. Classification and Severity

Each nonconformity must be classified based on actual or potential impact. The classification determines containment urgency, approval level, due date, escalation, and verification requirements.

Severity	Criteria	Required response
Critical	Potential food safety hazard, regulatory breach, fraudulent record, shipment of unsafe product, loss of traceability, undeclared allergen, or serious worker safety risk.	Immediate containment, QA Manager and Senior Management notification, shipment stop if applicable, root cause within 3 business days.
Major	Systemic failure, repeated deviation, customer requirement breach, certification risk, supplier documentation failure, or product quality issue requiring formal CAPA.	Containment within 24 hours, corrective action plan within 5 business days, effectiveness verification required.
Minor	Isolated procedural gap, incomplete record with recoverable evidence, housekeeping issue, local training gap, or non-systemic administrative error.	Correction within 5 business days and corrective action where recurrence risk exists.
Observation	Opportunity for improvement or early warning that does not yet represent a requirement failure.	Preventive or improvement action assigned when useful; trend monitoring required.

Food safety rule

Any issue with possible food safety, legal, allergen, traceability, or intentional adulteration impact must be treated as at least Major until Quality Assurance completes the risk assessment.

7. Procedure

7.1 Identify and Report

1. Any employee detecting a deviation must notify the relevant supervisor and Quality Assurance immediately.
2. The reporter must preserve available evidence, including photographs, batch records, temperature logs, supplier documents, labels, samples, emails, audit notes, or witness statements.
3. The supervisor must prevent uncontrolled continuation of the affected activity when product quality, food safety, traceability, safety, or compliance may be affected.
4. Quality Assurance assigns a unique nonconformity number and opens the case in the Corrective Action Register.

7.2 Contain the Issue

Containment must be fast, practical, and documented. It is not the final corrective action; it is the immediate control that prevents the issue from expanding while the investigation is completed.

Issue type	Minimum containment
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Issue type	Minimum containment
Product issue	Place lot on Hold, block system release, segregate physical inventory, attach hold tag, notify warehouse and sales.
Supplier issue	Suspend lot approval, request missing documentation, increase inspection level, block future deliveries if risk is high.
Process issue	Stop affected line or step, isolate records, verify last acceptable check, inspect product since last confirmed control point.
Documentation issue	Secure current version, identify affected users, replace obsolete copy, open document correction if needed.
HSE issue	Stop unsafe work, isolate area, provide first response, notify HSE, investigate before restart.

7.3 Evaluate Product and Compliance Impact

Quality Assurance must evaluate whether the nonconformity affects product disposition, customer notification, certification claims, regulatory obligations, supplier approval, recall risk, worker safety, or document integrity.

- Identify affected product lots, dates, vessels, suppliers, production lines, customers, records, and inventory locations.
- Review whether traceability is complete one step back and one step forward.
- Check whether MSC Chain of Custody, BASC, HACCP, BRCGS, IFS Food, SMETA, or customer requirements are affected.
- Determine whether regulatory or customer notification is required before product release or continued shipment.
- Record the disposition decision: release, rework, downgrade, return, reject, destroy, re-label, re-inspect, or hold pending evidence.

7.4 Investigate Root Cause

Root cause analysis must be proportional to risk. Minor isolated errors may use a simple cause statement, while major and critical cases require documented analysis such as 5 Whys, fishbone, process review, record review, staff interview, equipment check, or supplier investigation.

The investigation must distinguish between the direct cause, the root cause, and the reason the issue escaped detection. Corrective actions that only retrain staff are not acceptable unless the investigation shows that the root cause was genuinely a training or competence gap.

Cause family	Examples to consider
People	Competence, fatigue, unclear accountability, lack of supervision, rushed work, contractor unfamiliarity.
Process	Missing step, unclear acceptance criteria, weak handover, no escalation path, ineffective verification.
Equipment	Calibration failure, logger malfunction, freezer instability, worn tools, inadequate maintenance.
Materials / suppliers	Incorrect species, poor documentation, temperature abuse before receipt, unapproved vessel, packaging failure.

Cause family	Examples to consider
Environment	High ambient heat, loading delay, sanitation pressure, layout constraint, pest exposure, emergency condition.
Management system	Obsolete document, weak audit follow-up, insufficient trend review, unclear owner, missing KPI trigger.

7.5 Define Corrective Action Plan

The corrective action plan must address the confirmed root cause, assign an owner, define due dates, describe objective evidence, and identify how effectiveness will be verified.

Plan element	Requirement
Action description	What will be changed, corrected, strengthened, or implemented.
Owner	Single accountable person responsible for execution and evidence submission.
Due date	Risk-based date; overdue actions require escalation.
Evidence required	Revised record, photograph, training attendance, validation data, supplier approval, calibration certificate, audit result, or system screenshot.
Effectiveness method	Follow-up audit, trend review, re-inspection, complaint trend, temperature data review, traceability test, or management verification.

7.6 Implement and Verify

- The action owner implements the approved action and submits evidence to Quality Assurance before the due date.
- Quality Assurance reviews the evidence to confirm that the action was implemented as approved.
- For major and critical cases, Quality Assurance performs effectiveness verification after a suitable operating period or after enough evidence is available.
- If the action is ineffective, the case remains open and a revised root cause analysis or additional corrective action is required.
- A case may be closed only when correction, containment, root cause, corrective action, evidence, and effectiveness verification are complete.

8. Due Dates and Escalation

Severity	Containment	Root cause	Closure target	Escalation
Critical	Immediate	3 business days	30 calendar days unless justified	Senior Management and QA Manager
Major	24 hours	5 business days	45 calendar days unless justified	QA Manager and Operations Manager
Minor	5 business days	10 business days if CAPA needed	60 calendar days	Process Owner and QA Supervisor
Observation	As assigned	As assigned	Improvement cycle	Process Owner

Overdue actions must be reviewed weekly by the Quality Assurance Manager. Repeated overdue actions must be escalated to management review and may trigger additional training, resource allocation, process redesign, or disciplinary review where appropriate.

9. Product Disposition Rules

Product affected by a nonconformity may not be released until Quality Assurance confirms that disposition criteria have been met. Disposition must protect consumers, customers, certification integrity, and legal compliance.

Disposition	Rule
Release	Allowed only when evidence confirms that requirements are met and traceability is complete.
Rework	Allowed when the process is approved, food safety is not compromised, and rework is traceable.
Downgrade	Allowed when customer, legal, species, and labeling requirements remain accurate.
Return to supplier	Allowed when ownership, documentation, transportation, and regulatory conditions permit.
Reject or destroy	Required when product is unsafe, illegal, unverifiable, contaminated, or not recoverable.
Hold	Used when evidence is pending and product cannot be released without further review.

10. Records and Evidence

Record	Purpose
Corrective Action Register	Central log of all nonconformities, CAPAs, owners, due dates, evidence, status, and closure.
Nonconformity Report Form	Case record documenting source, description, severity, evidence, affected lots, containment, root cause, actions, and approvals.
Product Hold / Release Record	Traceable record for segregated product, disposition decision, release authorization, rejection, rework, or destruction.
Root Cause Analysis Worksheet	5 Whys, fishbone, process review, or other approved method used for major and critical cases.
Training or Briefing Record	Evidence when competence, awareness, procedure change, or handover issue is part of the corrective action.
Effectiveness Verification Record	Audit result, monitoring trend, repeat inspection, complaint trend, or other evidence used to confirm closure.

Records must be retained according to the document inventory, customer requirements, certification requirements, and applicable legal retention periods. Digital records must remain searchable by code, lot, supplier, vessel, customer, date, severity, owner, and closure status.

11. KPIs and Trend Review

KPI	Target / trigger	Frequency	Owner
Open CAPAs overdue	0 critical overdue; major overdue reviewed weekly	Weekly	QA Manager
Average closure time	Improving trend; no unmanaged aging	Monthly	Quality Assurance

KPI	Target / trigger	Frequency	Owner
Repeat nonconformities	No repeat major finding from same root cause	Monthly	Process Owners
Supplier-related findings	Trend by supplier/vessel and severity	Monthly	Procurement and QA
Customer complaints linked to CAPA	100% evaluated for root cause need	Monthly	Customer Service and QA
Audit finding closure	Closed by agreed due date with evidence	Per audit cycle	Internal Audit Lead

12. Risk Controls

Risk	Impact	Control
Superficial root cause	Corrective actions repeat because only the symptom was addressed.	QA challenge review; require evidence of root cause for major/critical cases.
Weak containment	Affected product or record continues moving before evaluation.	Mandatory hold/release protocol and immediate escalation for food safety or traceability risk.
Overdue actions	Audit exposure and recurrence risk increase.	Weekly overdue report and escalation to management review.
Poor evidence	Closure cannot be defended during customer or certification audit.	Evidence checklist and document controller review.
Supplier recurrence	Same supplier or vessel repeats documentation, temperature, or quality failures.	Supplier scorecard, increased inspection, conditional approval, or suspension.
Data fragmentation	CAPA evidence stored in emails or local folders is lost.	Central corrective action register and document inventory cross-reference.

13. Internal References

Code	Document
BSF-CORP-001	Corporate Profile
BSF-CORP-002	Corporate Glossary
BSF-DOC-STD-001	Corporate Document Standard
BSF-CORP-004	Corporate Knowledge Map
BSF-HR-001	Employee Onboarding Guide
BSF-HR-002	Employee FAQ
BSF-HR-003	Leave and Benefits Policy
BSF-HSE-001	Workplace Safety Procedure
BSF-HSE-002	Emergency Response Guide
BSF-OPS-001	Cold Chain Control Register
BSF-OPS-002	Authorized Fishing Vessels
BSF-OPS-003	Seafood Species Catalog
BSF-OPS-004	Seafood Receiving and Inspection Procedure
BSF-QMS-001	Quality Management Induction
BSF-QMS-002	Certification and Compliance Overview
BSF-INV-001	Document Inventory
BSF-INV-002	Document Ownership Matrix
BSF-INV-003	Document Sources and Ingestion Plan

Code	Document
BSF-INV-004	Document Curation and Quality Criteria
BSF-INV-005	Access and Permissions Policy

14. External Standards Alignment

Reference	Relevant alignment
ISO 9001	Nonconformity, corrective action, customer satisfaction, internal audit, performance evaluation, continual improvement.
HACCP / Codex	Hazard control, monitoring deviations, corrective action for critical limits, verification, records.
BRCGS Food Safety	Product safety culture, corrective action, root cause, incident management, supplier approval, traceability.
IFS Food	Nonconformity control, corrective actions, risk management, process control, product defense, internal audits.
SMETA / Sedex	Worker safety, ethical compliance, working conditions, management systems, corrective action tracking.
MSC Chain of Custody	Traceability, certified product segregation, claim control, subcontractor control, corrective action for integrity gaps.
BASC	Supply chain security, risk control, incident response, corrective action, documentation and access controls.

15. Appendices

Appendix A: Minimum Nonconformity Report Fields

- Case number, date, reporter, department, source, severity, affected process, supplier, vessel, lot, customer, and product code.
- Description of the nonconformity with objective evidence.
- Immediate containment and product disposition status.
- Root cause analysis method and conclusion.
- Corrective action plan with owner, due date, evidence, and approval.
- Effectiveness verification method, result, verifier, and closure date.

Appendix B: Effectiveness Verification Examples

Case type	Suggested verification
Temperature deviation	Review next 10 temperature records, confirm calibration, and verify no repeat excursion.
Documentation gap	Audit five recent records after retraining or form revision.
Supplier issue	Review next three deliveries and supplier evidence before returning to normal inspection level.
Label error	Verify revised label approval, line clearance checks, and first production run after change.
Audit finding	Perform follow-up audit against the original requirement and objective evidence.

Appendix C: Approval and Change History

Version	Date	Change description	Approval
1.0	2026-07-21	Initial controlled version prepared for review.	Quality Assurance Manager